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THE NEWS

REAL NEWS · CLEAR CONTEXT · SMARTER READING

TODAY: INDIA BLOC MOVES PRESIDENT · RUPEE 96.72 · SENSEX +879 6:00 AM IST EDITION · 6 PAGES

TOP STORY · POLITY & ELECTIONS

Opposition takes 'vote theft' charge to President Murmu

A 10-member INDIA bloc delegation met the President on Friday night; Rashtrapati Bhavan rejects the Leader of the Opposition's account, and a youth movement's march tests the capital's security clampdown.

A ten-member delegation of the opposition INDIA bloc met President Droupadi Murmu at Rashtrapati Bhavan on Friday evening and submitted a memorandum alleging large-scale "vote chori" (vote theft), demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the suspension of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The delegation, led by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi, included TMC chief Mamata Banerjee, J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah and CPI(M)'s M.A. Baby, among others. The memorandum sought repeal of the 2023 law governing the CEC's appointment, restoration of voters it says were wrongly deleted, a return to ballot papers, and a review of assembly elections held over two years.

BACKGROUND. The row centres on the SIR, a re-verification drive under which, the Opposition says, more than 13.3 crore names were removed; Election Commission data attributes the deletions largely to relocation, death and duplication.

WHY IT MATTERS. The credibility of the body that runs the world's largest elections is at stake, with seven states, including Uttar Pradesh, due to vote in 2027.

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT. The Opposition will submit evidence to the President and meet the Chief Justice on Monday, as a protest by the youth-led Cockroach Janata Party is planned in Delhi on Saturday.

Sources: The Hindu | Indian Express | PTI | Reuters | India Today | Rashtrapati Bhavan

Government rejects charge; President's office calls remarks 'incorrect'

Government sources said the "vote theft" claim was false and that it was "unfortunate" the President had been drawn into the controversy; Rashtrapati Bhavan described the Leader of the Opposition's account as incorrect. Sources: India Today | PTI

Capital turns into a fortress ahead of Saturday's march

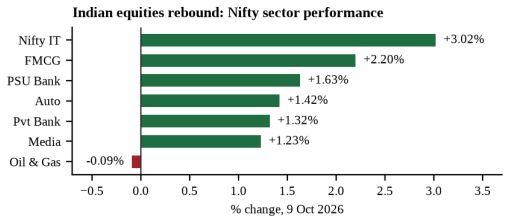
Thousands of police were deployed and 57 Delhi Metro stations were told to shut gates, while long-distance trains were curtailed. On Friday the Supreme Court said such measures must be proportionate. Sources: Reuters | SC order | HT

TODAY IN 60 SECONDS

- **Markets:** Sensex +879 pts to 72,472; Nifty above 22,500, snapping an eight-week losing streak.
- **Rupee:** recovers 16 paise to 96.72 after RBI intervention.
- **Panama:** magnitude 7.7 earthquake; canal unaffected, flights halted.
- **US–Russia:** Trump says Russia will supply 300,000 t of diesel; Zelensky calls it "weak".
- **Ukraine:** Russian glide-bomb strike on buses in Kramatorsk kills at least 30.
- **Nobel:** Navi Pillay wins the Peace Prize for international law.
- **Tech:** US bars Infosys, TCS, Wipro and others from a green-card labour programme.

NUMBERS OF THE DAY

Sensex close (9 Oct)	72,472.33
Nifty close	22,520.45
Rupee / US$	96.72
FII selling, Thu	₹12,944 cr
Monsoon deficit	−13%
Names off rolls (est.)	13.3 crore



Indian equities staged a broad rebound on 9 October, led by IT and FMCG shares after TCS's quarterly results. Source: NSE data, compiled by THE NEWS.

WHY IT MATTERS

A constitutional fight over the voter roll, an energy shock from the Gulf reaching India's rupee, and a tech race reshaping careers.

WORLD

Trump says Russia to send diesel; Kyiv calls it a 'gift to Putin'

President Donald Trump said on Friday that Russia had agreed to supply more than 300,000 tonnes of diesel to the US and global markets, with more to follow. Ukraine's Volodymyr Zelensky called the decision "unworthy" and "weak". The move comes as US diesel prices sit near a record high. Sources: Reuters | AFP | NDTV

INDIA · BUSINESS

Sensex vaults 879 points as IT stocks lead a relief rally

Bourses snapped an eight-week losing streak. The Sensex gained 1.23% and the Nifty 1.30%, after the RBI's 25-bps repo hike to 5.5% and record foreign selling had dragged indices to multi-month lows. The rupee closed at 96.72 and Brent eased to about $102.90 a barrel. Sources: BusinessLine | CNBC-TV18 | ET

TECHNOLOGY · CAREER

US suspends Indian IT majors from green-card labour programme

The US Labor Department suspended Infosys, TCS, Wipro, HCL, Cognizant, Capgemini, Microsoft and Adobe from the PERM certification process, alleging abuse. H-1B status is unaffected, but employer-sponsored green-card timelines stall. Sources: Indian Express | Mint | NDTV

SCIENCE

Nobel Peace Prize goes to jurist Navi Pillay

The Norwegian Nobel Committee awarded the 2026 Peace Prize to former UN human rights chief and ICJ judge Navanethem "Navi" Pillay for her efforts to promote peace and international law. The committee said the award was a reminder that right must come before might. Sources: NobelPrize.org | BBC | UN News

WORLD

Russian strike on Kramatorsk buses kills at least 30

A guided bomb hit two passenger buses in the eastern Ukrainian city. Donetsk's governor accused Russia of deliberately targeting civilians; public transport was suspended in Kramatorsk and Sloviansk. At least 35 people were killed across Donetsk on Thursday, officials said. Sources: AP | AFP | DW

QUOTE OF THE DAY — "The rule of law, both nationally and internationally, is the very backbone of a system that safeguards peace and the non-violent resolution of conflicts." *Norwegian Nobel Committee, on awarding the 2026 Peace Prize to Navi Pillay.*

Iran strikes a gas carrier near Hormuz as Gulf tensions widen

Tehran's Revolutionary Guards say they hit an LPG carrier; Saudi Arabia says Houthi forces were pushed from Bab al-Mandab.

Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) said on Friday that it struck a large LPG carrier, the NV Sunshine, south of the Strait of Hormuz, claiming the vessel was "attempting to pass through the illegal route". The Guards warned that vessels using routes Tehran considers unauthorised could face action across the wider region. The claim has not been independently confirmed.

Separately, Saudi Arabia's ambassador to Yemen said remaining Houthi forces had been driven from the Bab al-Mandab area, and the Saudi-led coalition said it was conducting a "large-scale operation" against Houthi fighters. Two attacks on Riyadh's King Khalid International Airport killed three Saudi citizens.

WHY IT MATTERS. The Strait of Hormuz and Bab al-Mandab are the Gulf's two most important energy chokepoints. Disruption there feeds directly into crude prices — which closed near $103 a barrel on Friday — and into India's import bill, inflation and currency.

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT. President Trump said the situation with Iran was "going to be over soon, one way or the other", while signalling Washington would refrain from further military action before the November midterms.

Sources: Al Jazeera | Indian Express | Reuters | Straits Times

A week of escalation: Middle East and Ukraine

- **Oct 7** — Russia missile hits Pryluky flats; 22 killed
- **Oct 8** — Russian glide bomb on Kramatorsk buses; 30+ killed
- **Oct 8** — IRGC says it struck LPG carrier near Hormuz
- **Oct 9** — Trump: Russia to supply 300,000t diesel; Zelensky objects
- **Oct 9** — Saudi-led coalition pushes Houthis from Bab al-Mandab

Developments in the Middle East and Ukraine over the past week. Sources: Reuters, AP, AFP, Al Jazeera.

WORLD IN BRIEF

US–Russia. Trump said he had a "highly successful" call with Vladimir Putin on diesel; the Kremlin said the two also discussed Iran and Ukraine.

Panama. A magnitude 7.7 quake struck near Pitaloza Arriba; the canal kept operating, Tocumen airport halted flights, and power went down across six provinces.

ICC. The US imposed sanctions on the International Criminal Court, hours after a former ICC judge won the Nobel Peace Prize.

Lebanon. An Israeli drone attack near the Syrian border wounded six people, Al Jazeera reported.

EU–China. Brussels and Beijing averted a trade war with an understanding to moderate Chinese hybrid-car exports to the EU.

Ukraine. Kyiv said it struck a "major" refinery in Omsk and another in Ukhta.

MAP POINT · THE GULF CHOKEPOINTS

Strait of Hormuz — between Iran and Oman; the world's most important oil transit point. **Bab al-Mandab** — between Yemen and the Horn of Africa; the gateway to the Suez route.

Sources: Reuters | Al Jazeera

BY THE NUMBERS

Brent crude	**$102.90**
Diesel pledged	**300,000 t**
Kramatorsk toll	**30+**
Panama quake	**M 7.7**

QUOTE

"Gifts to Putin will not bring peace or any benefit to the civilized world." — *Volodymyr Zelensky.*

EU and China reach a deal to 'halve' hybrid-car exports

After two days of talks in Beijing, EU trade commissioner Maroš Šefčovič and China's commerce minister Wang Wentao said they had reached a shared understanding to moderate Chinese exports of hybrid and plug-in hybrid vehicles, with Brussels projecting that shipments could fall by more than half over four years. China also agreed to lower tariffs on European car parts, olive oil and footwear and to ease export licensing for rare earths. Šefčovič called it "a crucial first step". Sources: AP | Guardian | Nikkei Asia | EUobserver

Navi Pillay wins the Nobel Peace Prize for international law

The Norwegian Nobel Committee awarded the 2026 Peace Prize to Navanethem "Navi" Pillay, a South African jurist, former UN High Commissioner for Human Rights and judge at the International Court of Justice. The committee said her work had been "instrumental in ensuring that war crimes, crimes against humanity and genocide are prosecuted", and used the award to stress that the rule of law underpins peace. She is South Africa's fifth Peace laureate. Sources: NobelPrize.org | BBC | NPR | UN News

Panama quake shakes a region already on edge

A magnitude 7.7 earthquake and dozens of aftershocks struck southern Panama on Friday, damaging homes, cutting power and halting flights. The Panama Canal, about 200 km from the epicentre, operated normally. Authorities reported injuries but no confirmed deaths by Friday evening. The USGS said 4.6 million people felt moderate-to-severe shaking and that losses could reach 1–10% of GDP. It followed devastating quakes in Colombia and Venezuela this year. Sources: BBC | AP | Reuters | NBC News

Russia–Ukraine: the deadliest single strike this year

A Russian guided bomb hit two passenger buses in Kramatorsk, a front-line city in Donetsk, killing at least 30 and wounding about 18; the regional toll across Donetsk on Thursday reached 35. Governor Vadym Filashkin accused Russia of deliberately targeting civilians. Ukraine's allies say the attacks underscore the need for air defence; the strike followed a missile attack that killed 22 in Pryluky. Sources: AP | AFP | DW | Euronews

MIDDLE EAST

US sanctions the ICC, widening a rift with Europe

Washington sanctioned the International Criminal Court hours after a former ICC judge won the Nobel Peace Prize, potentially punishing firms that serve the court. European allies criticised the move. Sources: Straits Times | Reuters

AMERICAS

Panama's rare quake tests a preparedness plan

The country had scheduled a national earthquake evacuation drill for Monday. Officials said damage was concentrated in Veraguas, Herrera and Los Santos, with a colonial church collapsed in Los Santos. Sources: Reuters | AP

EUROPE

Brussels buys time on trade, but the deficit persists

The EU's goods deficit with China runs above €1 billion a day. Šefčovič said "dialogue requires results" and that Brussels would use its own instruments where talks fall short, with a follow-up call in January and a third round of talks in March.

Sources: EUobserver | Nikkei Asia

Supreme Court tells Centre: don't 'use a hammer to kill a fly'

The court ordered that Delhi's metro and rail services not be shut down entirely ahead of Saturday's protest, invoking the principle of proportionality.

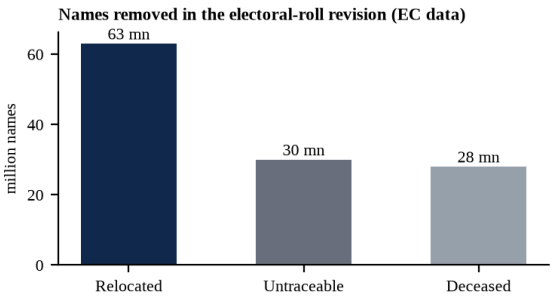
FACT. A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana directed the Centre on Friday to ensure there is no "complete prohibition" on metro and railway services to Delhi on 10 October, after 57 metro stations were told to close gates and long-distance trains were curtailed.

CLAIM. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, for the Centre and Delhi Police, said restrictions were needed to prevent unlawful gatherings and cited injuries to police in an earlier protest; he agreed to reconsider the curbs.

RESPONSE. The court held that "regulation and a complete prohibition are two different measures", and that security measures must be proportionate and not cause hardship to commuters, students and workers. It directed wide publicity for revised advisories.

NEXT STEP. Authorities were asked to review road closures and barricading and to allow traffic where restrictions are not necessary.

Sources: Supreme Court order | The Hindu | Hindustan Times | New Indian Express



Election Commission data, cited in reporting, on the reasons for deletions during the roll revision. Source: Election Commission via Reuters.

SC rejects Andhra Pradesh plea on 34% BC quota

The Supreme Court dismissed Andhra Pradesh's appeal against a High Court ruling that struck down its move to restore 34% reservation for Backward Classes in local bodies, holding that a unified family survey was insufficient to justify breaching the 50% ceiling. A special Cabinet meeting is due on Saturday. Source: The Hindu

GST Council clears process overhaul

The 57th GST Council meeting left rates unchanged but scrapped tax officers' arrest powers, raised the prosecution threshold fivefold to ₹5 crore, automated refunds and widened input-tax-credit refunds, including on input services from 1 November 2026.

Sources: ET | Indian Express | Mint

INDIA IN BRIEF

Rural jobs. Demand under the new VB-G RAM G scheme rose 25.2% in September to 15.6 million households from 12.5 million in August.

Skills. PM Modi told WorldSkills participants that youth must continuously upgrade skills; India finished 10th in Shanghai.

UP. The state cabinet approved a ₹1,725-crore skill-training network across all 75 districts.

Space. ISRO said about 95% of Gaganyaan's initial-phase tests are complete; the first uncrewed flight is targeted around the GSLV-F18/NVS-03 window.

Rupee. The RBI's Monetary Policy Report flagged headwinds from a strong dollar and elevated import costs.

Punjab. CM Mann launched HUNAR, a workforce-matching platform linking industry, institutions and skilled workers.

Defence. The Supreme Court pressed the Centre on welfare for cadets boarded out during training.

Sources: ET | TOI | PIB | ISRO | RBI | Tribune

ECONOMY

RBI's 25-bps hike, and a rupee that refuses to rally

The Reserve Bank raised the repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.5% and shifted its stance to "calibrated tightening" — a signal that inflation and financial conditions remain a concern. The rupee, down about 7% this year, recovered 16 paise to close at 96.72 after the central bank intervened heavily. The RBI's Monetary Policy Report warned the currency could face headwinds from a strong dollar and costlier imports.

Sources: BusinessLine | ET | PTI

AGRICULTURE · CLIMATE

A 13% monsoon deficit puts food prices under strain

The southwest monsoon ended 13% below the long-period average — the driest since 2015 — leaving reservoir storage at 71.8% of capacity against 90.3% a year ago. Rice acreage fell 3.5% to 433.62 lakh hectares; onion prices were up 93% year-on-year in September, and rice millers reported paddy at ₹4,000 a quintal. Southern states are now banking on the northeast monsoon. Sources: Business Standard | Mint | The Hindu | DW

SPACE

Gaganyaan edges closer as an NVS-03 decision looms

ISRO is weighing whether to launch the NVS-03 navigation satellite with an open or closed pyro valve, after the NVS-02 propulsion failure left NavIC depleted. A parliamentary committee has said replacement satellites NVS-03 to NVS-05 will launch over 15–18 months. Crew-module integration for Gaganyaan-G1 is complete, and ISRO said NVS-03's launch configuration will be decided after studies. Sources: The Federal | ISRO | Indian Defence News

GOVERNANCE

Supreme Court presses Centre on cadet welfare

A bench of Justices B.V. Nagarathna, R. Mahadevan and D.K. Upadhyaya rebuked the Centre for not genuinely reconsidering the 2015 Sabharwal Committee's recommendations on welfare for officer cadets boarded out due to training injuries, giving it one more opportunity to comply. The court noted that ordinary recruits get disability pension while officer cadets do not. The matter returns on 30 November. Source: PTI

EMPLOYMENT

Rural demand surges as the farm year tightens

Work demand under VB-G RAM G jumped a quarter in September, a sign of stress in rain-fed districts after the weak monsoon. The scheme guarantees 125 days of employment and a ₹300 minimum daily wage. Source: ET

HEALTH

Cancer-drug price cap lifts hospital stocks

Hospital shares rose on Friday after a government cap on cancer-drug prices came in lower than expected; Apollo Hospitals was among the top Nifty gainers, up nearly 5%. Sources: CNBC-TV18 | Upstox

STATES

AP declares drought in 388 mandals

Andhra Pradesh has declared drought in 388 of its mandals, and drought assessment is under way in Rajasthan, as the uneven monsoon hits cotton, paddy and pulses. Sources: CNBC-TV18 | Business Standard

EDUCATION

Skill centres expand as global jobs beckon

Uttarakhand said 106 youths secured overseas jobs under a state scheme, mostly in Japan and Saudi Arabia, as states push foreign-language and vocational training. Sources: TOI | Tribune

ALSO IN INDIA — Food inflation rose to 5.95% in August, pushing retail inflation to a 20-month high; hydropower generation fell nearly 16% in September as reservoir levels dropped; and the Opposition said it will hand the Chief Justice of India a memorandum on Monday. Rural work demand under the VB-G RAM G scheme rose 25.2% in September.

The AI race moves from models to systems that get work done

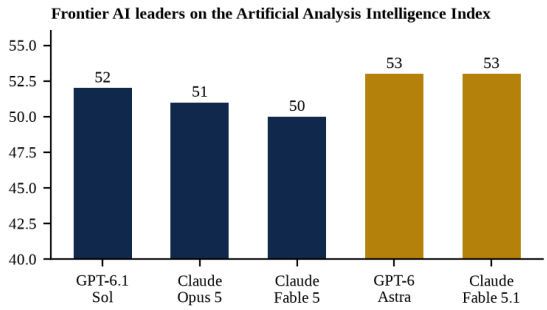
Google, OpenAI, Anthropic and Microsoft each answered the same question this week: who can build the most useful, secure and scalable agent platform?

At a Google Cloud event, the company launched the Gemini agent — a unified assistant that takes "objectives, not just instructions", plans work, uses tools and connects to business systems such as Google Workspace, Microsoft 365, Slack, Jira, BigQuery and Snowflake. CEO Sundar Pichai said Gemini has over a billion monthly active users and that nearly 90% of Fortune 100 firms use Gemini Enterprise.

OpenAI published 722 mathematical manuscripts grouped into 372 families of findings and pushed its GPT-6.1 Sol model, which the developer says nearly matches its flagship GPT-6 Astra at a fraction of the cost. Anthropic launched a Critical Infrastructure Defense Program and an opt-in OSS Scanner that scans open-source projects for vulnerabilities free of charge. Microsoft moved agents onto the PC with new "execution containers" that restrict what an agent can reach.

WHY IT MATTERS. For engineers, the differentiator is shifting from raw model capability to orchestration, cost control and governance. The UK's Information Commissioner's Office said ten AI developers had committed to data-protection improvements and opened a call for evidence on agentic-AI risks.

Sources: Google Cloud | TechCrunch | Anthropic | OpenAI | Reuters | UK ICO



Composite scores on Artificial Analysis' Intelligence Index; Anthropic and OpenAI share the top band. Source: State of AI Report 2026 / Artificial Analysis.

AI / ML EXPLAINER · AGENTIC AI

An **agent** is a model given a goal plus the ability to act: it plans, calls tools or APIs, reads results and iterates until the task is done. Unlike a chatbot that answers, an agent *executes*. The new governance questions are permissions, audit trails and cost caps — which is why this week's launches emphasise "tasks inboxes", model routing and spend limits.

DATA ANALYST TAKEAWAY

Agent platforms now expose their own telemetry. Treat agent runs like any pipeline: log inputs, tool calls, latency and cost per run. Asana's browser-agent study cut model cost 76× and run time 5× mainly through **history management and caching** — 89% of input tokens came from cache. Caching and context budgeting are now first-class analytics levers.

US bars Indian IT firms from the PERM green-card programme

The US Labor Department suspended Infosys, TCS, Wipro, HCL, Cognizant and Capgemini — plus Microsoft and Adobe — from the Permanent Labor Certification (PERM) programme, alleging abuse and displacement of American workers. The action does not cancel H-1B status, but it blocks new filings and pauses pending ones, delaying employer-sponsored green cards. Nasscom said immigration and skilled-talent mobility should not be conflated. Sources: Indian Express | Mint | CNBC-TV18 | Nasscom

PYTHON / SQL TIP

When you measure cost per task, segment by **cache hit rate**, not just by model:

```
SELECT model, AVG(cost_usd) AS cost,
AVG(cache_hit) AS hit_rate
FROM agent_runs GROUP BY model;
```

Compare like-for-like on *completed* tasks only — failed runs hide the real unit cost.

METRIC TO WATCH

Cost per *completed* task — not cost per call. A cheap model that fails and retries is more expensive than a pricier one that finishes first time.

CAREER TAKEAWAY

The PERM freeze and H-1B scrutiny make the US employer-sponsored route less certain for Indian tech workers. In demand: on-device and edge AI, agent evaluation, AI security and data governance — the roles the four big platforms all flagged this week. Build demonstrable skills in evaluation and cost engineering; those translate across employers and borders.

SKILL SIGNALS

- Agent evaluation and red-teaming.
- Data governance and audit trails.
- Cost engineering for LLM pipelines.
- On-device / edge inference.

TECH IN BRIEF

DevDay. OpenAI introduced GPT-6.1 Sol, "Dots" personal agents, an Ultrafast tier and a $500/month Pro plan.

Open source. Anthropic's OSS Scanner offers free vulnerability scans, reporting a true-positive rate above 90%.

Cyber. Anthropic's Critical Infrastructure Defense Program partners include CrowdStrike, Palo Alto Networks and PwC.

Models. The State of AI Report says the cost of reaching a fixed benchmark score fell about 47% per quarter since 2023.

Chips. A sell-off in global chip shares weighed on Asian markets before Friday's rebound.

REGULATION

Regulators turn their attention to agents

The UK ICO's call for evidence on agentic AI signals formal guidance on permissions, data access and accountability is coming — a factor in regulated enterprise procurement. Source: UK ICO

DATA ENGINEERING

MCP becomes the connective tissue

Google's agent can connect to any Model Context Protocol server inside or outside a firm's network — making MCP a de-facto standard for wiring tools into agents. Sources: TechCrunch | Google Cloud

INDUSTRY

IT services count the cost of US curbs

Analysts said Indian IT firms have cut reliance on H-1B and expanded US local hiring, limiting the immediate hit from the PERM suspension even as talent retention gets harder. Sources: CNBC-TV18 | Nasscom

SEMICONDUCTORS

Chip shares slide, then steady

A sell-off in global chip stocks pulled Asia lower before Friday's recovery. Sources: Business Standard | Upstox

ENTERPRISE AI

Cost control becomes a feature

Google said multi-model routing and spend caps would help firms control AI costs. Source: Google Cloud

CAREERS

Evaluation skills in demand

Demand is rising for engineers who can test, evaluate and cap agent cost. Source: THE NEWS

Markets snap an eight-week slide, but the overhangs remain

IT stocks led a relief rally after TCS's results; crude, bond yields and record FII selling still cloud the outlook.

The Sensex closed 879.09 points, or 1.23%, higher at 72,472.33 and the Nifty gained 288.65 points, or 1.30%, to 22,520.45 on Friday — snapping an eight-week losing streak. Every Nifty sectoral index ended in the green barring oil and gas; the IT index rose about 3% after TCS reported a 15% jump in net profit to ₹13,884 crore.

The rebound followed a bruising week in which the RBI's 25-bps repo hike to 5.5%, crude near $103 a barrel and record foreign outflows dragged the Sensex to a 32-month low. FPIs sold a net ₹12,944 crore on Thursday, their biggest single-day outflow since May, while domestic institutions bought ₹10,703 crore. The rupee closed at 96.72.

WHY IT MATTERS. India's equity market is now hostage to three forces it does not control: the oil price, US bond yields and global risk appetite. A sustained recovery still needs Q2 earnings to confirm.

Sources: BusinessLine | CNBC-TV18 | ET | Capital Market | Upstox

MARKET SNAPSHOT · 9 OCT 2026

INDEX	CLOSE	CHANGE
Sensex	72,472.33	+1.23%
Nifty 50	22,520.45	+1.30%
Nifty Bank	55,257	+1.36%
Nifty Midcap 100	58,787	+1.56%
Rupee / US$	96.72	+16p
Brent crude	$102.90	−1.32%
Gold (22ct, 1g)	₹13,895	+₹105
India VIX	14.35	−6.07%

Sources: NSE | BSE | PTI

CAREER TAKEAWAY

Friday's rally was led by IT on the back of TCS's numbers — in a risk-off market, earnings and cash flow, not sentiment, decide who outperforms. Sectors hiring most actively this cycle: IT services, BFSI technology and AI-enabled product roles.

DATA POINT

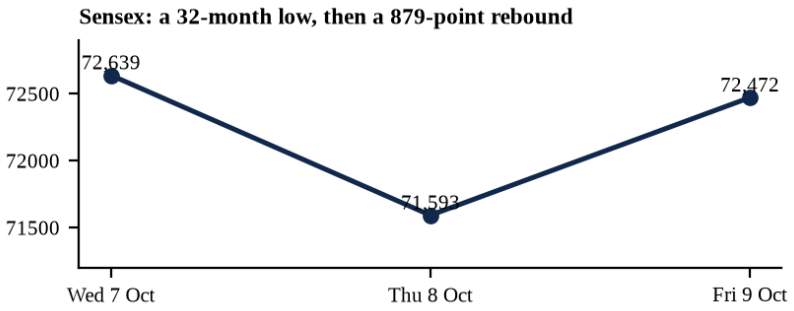
India's services trade surplus was about $17 billion in August against a merchandise deficit of $27 billion — the reason this week's GST changes for service exports matter more than they look.

ALSO TODAY

Gold. 22-carat gold rose ₹105 to ₹13,895 per gram; silver gained 1.64% to ₹2.24 lakh/kg.

IPO watch. BSE fell over 1% ahead of SEBI's final CAS paper.

ITC. The stock surged 4% after GQG exited via block deals.



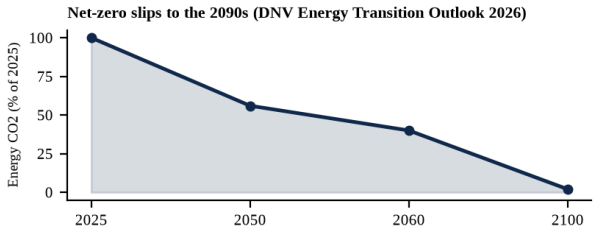
The Sensex hit a 32-month low on Thursday before Friday's rebound. Source: BSE data, compiled by THE NEWS.

SCIENCE

Three Nobels, three windows into how the world works

Medicine went to Karl Deisseroth, Peter Hegemann and Georg Nagel for optogenetics — using light to switch individual nerve cells on and off in a living brain. **Physics** honoured Francis Halzen for the IceCube Neutrino Observatory and the discovery of high-energy neutrinos of astrophysical origin. **Chemistry** recognised Henri Kagan and Kenso Soai for work on autocatalysis in asymmetric synthesis — the chemistry of "handedness", or how one mirror-image form of a molecule can come to dominate.

Sources: NobelPrize.org | Karolinska Institutet



Energy and process CO2 under DNV's Energy Transition Outlook 2026. Source: DNV via edie.

SCIENCE EXPLAINER · OPTOGENETICS

Some algae carry a protein, channelrhodopsin, that opens an ion channel when blue light strikes it. Insert its gene into a nerve cell and that cell becomes light-sensitive: flash blue light, and the neuron fires. This "light switch" lets researchers test causation — not just correlation — between specific circuits and memory, mood or behaviour, and is being explored to restore sight.

WHY IT MATTERS

Optogenetics turns a hypothesis about a brain circuit into an experiment you can run: switch it on or off, and watch what changes.

BUSINESS & SCIENCE IN BRIEF

GST. Refunds on input services from 1 Nov 2026; on plant and machinery from 1 Apr 2027, spread over 60 months.

Climate. WMO says El Niño will intensify to record levels this quarter, with drier-than-normal conditions over the Indian subcontinent.

Energy. DNV now sees net-zero around 2098 and about 2.3°C of warming by 2100.

Methane. The IEA's Global Methane Tracker 2026 updates energy-sector emissions estimates.

BUSINESS

GST reforms target working capital, not rates

The package automates 90% provisional refunds and lets firms monetise input-tax credit locked under an inverted duty structure. Sources: ET | Indian Express

CAREER

Skills, not degrees, as the jobs imperative

The CEA argued India must put employment, entrepreneurship and human capital at the centre of growth. Sources: Inclusion | PIB

MARKETS

FPIs sell, DIIs buy

Thursday's ₹12,944-crore foreign outflow was met by ₹10,703 crore of domestic buying. Source: BusinessLine

PRELIMS CORNER

Electoral roll revision (SIR). Conducted by the ECI under the Representation of the People Act, 1950. Constitutional anchor: Art. 324.

Repo rate. Raised 25 bps to 5.5%; stance changed to "calibrated tightening". MPC has six members; inflation target 4% ± 2%.

GST Council. Art. 279A; 57th meeting; Section 69 of the CGST Act omitted.

Strait of Hormuz. Connects the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman; key oil chokepoint.

IceCube. Neutrino observatory at the South Pole; Nobel Physics 2026.

El Niño. Warming of the central/eastern equatorial Pacific; suppresses the Indian monsoon.

Optogenetics. Light-controlled switch for nerve cells; Nobel Medicine 2026.

TERMS TO REMEMBER

Proportionality — a constitutional test that state action must be the least restrictive means necessary. **Inverted duty structure** — when tax on inputs exceeds tax on output, trapping input-tax credit. **Place of supply** — the rule fixing where a transaction is taxed. **Homochirality** — life's preference for one mirror-image form of a molecule.

SOCIAL ISSUES · DEFENCE

Social: rural job demand up 25.2% in September; skill-mission push across states. **Defence:** SC presses the Centre on welfare for cadets boarded out during training.

KEY SCHEMES & LAWS

VB-G RAM G Act, 2025 — 125 days' rural work, ₹300 daily wage. **RP Act, 1950** — roll revision.

ISSUE ANALYSIS · THE SIR AND THE CREDIBILITY OF THE ECI

What happened: A nationwide Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls has removed, per reporting, over 13 crore names. The Opposition alleges "vote theft" and wants the CEC to resign; the government and ECI deny manipulation and say deletions remove dead, relocated and duplicate entries.

Background: The 2023 law on appointments of Election Commissioners, and the SIR begun last year, are the flashpoints. Two Election Commissioners reportedly recorded formal objections to SIR decisions over ten months.

Why important: The ECI is the constitutional guarantor of free and fair elections (Art. 324). Erosion of trust in it carries systemic risk in the world's largest democracy.

Context: Art. 324 vests superintendence of elections in the ECI; the SC has held that the 50% ceiling on reservation applies unless backwardness is empirically established (Vikas Kishanrao Gawali, 2021).

Challenges: Balancing roll accuracy with the right to vote; transparency in deletions; protecting the ECI's independence while keeping it accountable.

Way forward: Publish auditable deletion data with reasons; time-bound grievance redress; statutory clarity on appointments and removal of Commissioners; weigh the ballot-paper demand only on evidence.

WAY FORWARD · DETAIL

Publish auditable deletion data with reasons; set a time-bound grievance-redress window; clarify in statute the appointment and removal process for Commissioners; and treat the ballot-paper demand as a separate question to be weighed on evidence, not assumed.

CASE LAW & NUMBERS

Vikas Kishanrao Gawali (2021) — a contemporaneous empirical inquiry into backwardness is a prerequisite for reservation breaching the 50% ceiling; cited again in this week's Andhra Pradesh ruling.

Names removed (est.)	**13.3 cr**
Recorded objections	**14**
States voting 2027	**7**

MAINS CORNER

"The credibility of an electoral body is its greatest asset." Discuss with reference to the SIR of electoral rolls. *(GS-II)*

Examine how a weak southwest monsoon transmits into food inflation and rural demand. Suggest policy responses. *(GS-III)*

India's space programme is shifting from capability to commercialisation. Analyse the role of Gaganyaan and NavIC. *(GS-III)*

Discuss the implications for India of the US crackdown on the H-1B and PERM routes. *(GS-II/III)*

"Chokepoint politics in the Gulf is India's energy problem." Comment. *(GS-II)*

IR · ECONOMY · ENVIRONMENT

IR: US–Russia diesel deal; Iran's Hormuz actions; EU–China hybrid-car understanding; Nobel Peace Prize to Navi Pillay for international law.

Economy: RBI hikes repo to 5.5%; rupee near 96.7; GST process reforms; record FII outflows.

Environment: 13% monsoon deficit; El Niño at record strength (WMO); DNV sees 2.3°C warming; military-emissions reporting weakens (CEOBS).

CASE STUDIES

Governance: SIR and the ECI's independence.

Economy: RBI's calibrated tightening.

Environment: 2026 monsoon deficit and rabi risk.

IR: Gulf chokepoints and India's energy security.

REPORTS & INDICES · MAP & GEOGRAPHY

WMO Global Seasonal Climate Update — El Niño to peak near record +3.7°C (Niño 3.4); drier-than-normal Indian subcontinent.

DNV Energy Transition Outlook 2026 — net-zero around 2098; 2.3°C warming.

IEA Global Methane Tracker 2026 — energy-sector methane estimates.

10 New Insights in Climate Science — ocean heat, ice loss, water stress.

Geography: Panama sits on the Pacific "Ring of Fire"; the Azuero–Soná fault system caused the 7.7 quake.

ANSWER APPROACH · A MODEL STRUCTURE

For the SIR question: **Intro** — define SIR and the ECI's mandate under Art. 324. **Body** — the case for accuracy of rolls vs. the right to vote; cite the 14 recorded objections and the 13-crore deletion figure with attribution; note the 50% ceiling ruling. **Conclusion** — institutional trust as public good; a time-bound, auditable redress mechanism.

CURRENT AFFAIRS MCQS

The 2026 Nobel Peace Prize was awarded to:
(a) Maria Corina Machado (b) Navi Pillay (c) Narges Mohammadi (d) UNICEF

The Strait of Hormuz connects the Persian Gulf to:
(a) Red Sea (b) Gulf of Aden (c) Gulf of Oman (d) Mediterranean Sea

The RBI's repo rate after the October 2026 policy is:
(a) 5.25% (b) 5.50% (c) 6.00% (d) 6.50%

The IceCube Neutrino Observatory is located at:
(a) Andes (b) South Pole (c) Kolar (d) Atacama

India's 2026 southwest monsoon ended with a deficit of about:
(a) 5% (b) 9% (c) 13% (d) 21%

The 2026 Nobel Prize in Chemistry was awarded for work on:
(a) mRNA vaccines (b) click chemistry (c) chirality/autocatalysis (d) quantum dots

Answers: 1-b, 2-c, 3-b, 4-b, 5-c, 6-c

POLITY · GOVERNANCE · AGRICULTURE

Polity: SC on proportionality of transport curbs; AP BC quota plea rejected; SC on cadet welfare.

Governance: GST Council process reforms; prosecution threshold raised to ₹5 crore; Section 69 omitted.

Agriculture: Rice acreage down 3.5%; pulses and oilseeds up; onion prices +93% y-o-y; AP drought in 388 mandals.

Space: Gaganyaan-G1 crew module integrated; NVS-03 pyro-valve decision pending.

PRELIMS PRACTICE · MATCH THE REPORT

Match: (i) El Niño strength — (ii) net-zero 2098 — (iii) energy methane — (iv) ocean heat.
A. DNV B. WMO C. IEA D. Future Earth.
Answer: i-B, ii-A, iii-C, iv-D.